
The Morning: Going for broke

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The New York Times The Morning

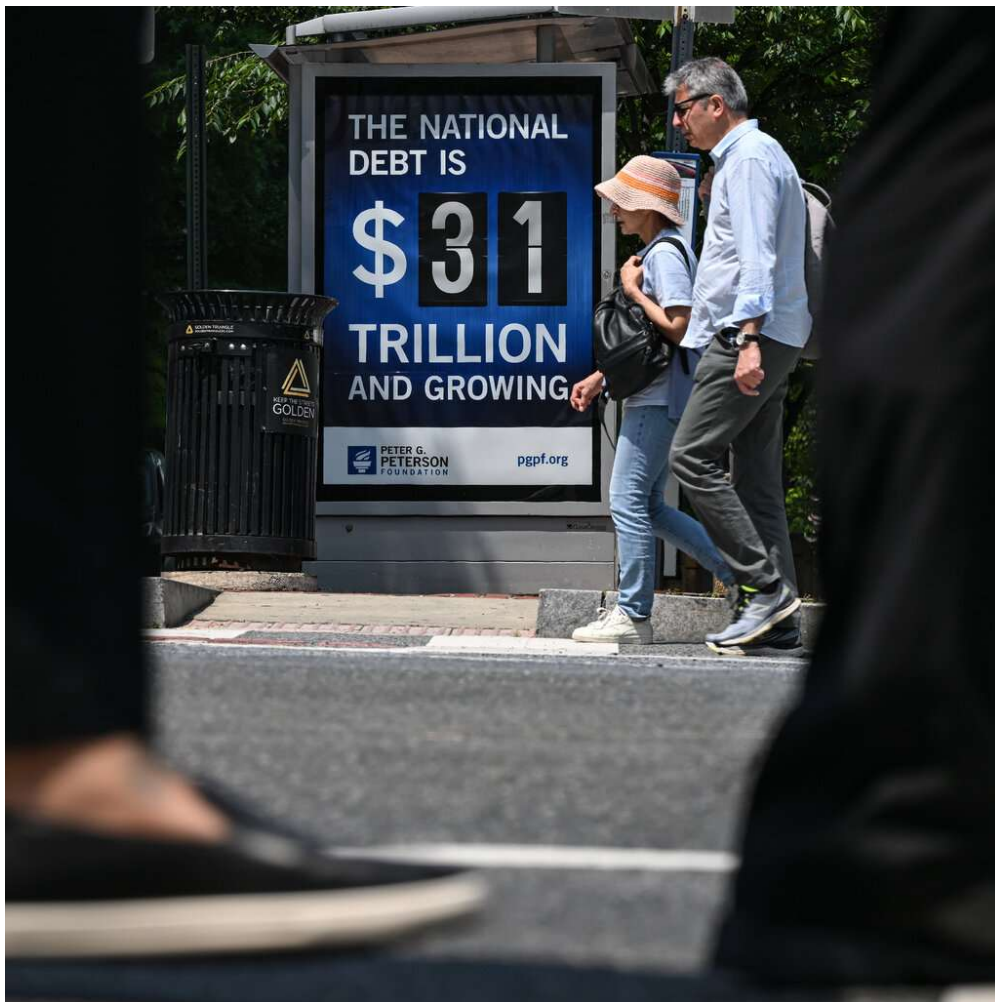
May 8, 2026



By Sam Sifton

Good morning. Iran and the U.S. exchanged strikes, and each side blamed the other for breaking their truce. President Trump insisted late last night the cease-fire was still in effect. [Follow the latest updates.](#)

We have more news below — and a dispatch from the American pavilion at the Venice Biennale. But first, I've asked my colleague Evan Gorelick what it means that America's national debt is bigger than its entire economy.



In Washington, D.C. Kenny Holston/The New York Times

Seeing red



By **Evan Gorelick**

I'm a writer for The Morning.

Not long ago, the national debt was a scandal. Economists said it would wreck the financial system. Voters stewed. [A 1990 poll](#) found that 76 percent of Americans regarded the deficit as “a very serious problem calling for immediate action.” Presidential candidates ran against it; the 1992 race was a referendum on different belt-tightening proposals. At the time, the debt was around \$4 trillion.

Now it's over \$31 trillion, bigger than our entire economy. Here's what that means: If the federal government were to demand, for an entire year, that all workers hand over 100 percent of their wages, that all landlords hand over 100 percent of their rents, that all investors hand over 100 percent of their capital returns and that all corporations hand over 100 percent of their profits, then at the end of that nightmarish year, the government would still be in debt.

That's not healthy. The United States hasn't held this much debt since World War II. And it's still growing, fast.

Public debt as a share of G.D.P.



Note: Excludes debt the federal government owes itself. Sources: Congressional Budget Office; Treasury Dept. Karl Russell/The New York Times

Yet [neither voters nor politicians seem worried](#), my colleague Tony Romm writes. Both parties keep [cutting taxes](#), even as aging Americans receive more money from Medicare and Social Security. Lawmakers keep spending more on the military. And the Treasury must make debt interest payments so huge that they exceed the annual cost of Medicare.

Our views on the debt, clearly, have changed. Why?

Caution to the wind

In the '80s, we treated government debt like personal debt. A red ledger reflected poor judgment and a corrupt character. It seemed “irresponsible, inequitable and immoral,” Steve Hanke, who served on Reagan’s Council of Economic Advisers, told me. Voters agreed, and they picked leaders who finally balanced the federal budget in 1998.

Then came a shift:

More economists began to say that debt was a *good* thing. Interest rates were low, which held down borrowing costs. Inflation was also low. Government spending stimulated growth and created jobs.

Both parties realized they could borrow money to pay for political candy — tax cuts, stimulus checks — without getting pummeled at the polls.

George W. Bush took that insight to the bank. He cut taxes while spending trillions to fight wars in Iraq and Afghanistan. After the 2008 mortgage crisis, the government spent trillions more to revive the economy. Borrowing kept rising, even as the conditions that made it tolerable disappeared. Interest compounded. A global pandemic later, and we're \$31 trillion in the hole.

The reckoning

The solutions to this problem have never changed: spend less, tax more, or both. But the urgency to deal with it is gone. Even the fiscal hawks in Congress voted last year for tax cuts that will increase the debt [by \\$3 trillion](#). Rating agencies have [downgraded our credit](#), and many economists say we're entering a period of protracted higher interest rates.

Can we keep borrowing forever? In about 20 years, no amount of tax hikes or spending cuts will be able to stop the country from defaulting on its debt, according to projections shared by Kent Smetters, an economist at Wharton.

If America defaults, the price of borrowing will skyrocket, starving businesses of cash and throwing the economy into crisis. Governments rarely allow that; instead, they often print money to pay. But doing so causes hyperinflation and makes everyone poorer. Both outcomes are terrible.

We're collectively betting that the country will grow its way out of this mess before then. If the economy gets bigger — say, because of an A.I. productivity boom — then Americans will get wealthier, and the government [may collect enough in taxes](#) to retire decades-old debt.

But economists expect the labor force to shrink, too, and displaced workers may need financial support. It could be a wash, Smetters told me. Without a new approach in Washington, the debt probably isn't going anywhere.

Related: On “Interesting Times,” the billionaire investor Ray Dalio warns that the U.S. is repeating fiscal mistakes that ended great empires. [Listen to the podcast here](#).

Back to you, Sam.



War in the Middle East

Despite exchanging strikes, American and Iranian officials said they had started discussing a proposal to [reopen the Strait of Hormuz and end hostilities](#) for 30 days while they work out a longer-term peace deal.

The White House approved another [\\$17 billion worth](#) in sales of missiles and related services to Gulf nations, despite worries inside the Pentagon about dwindling U.S. stockpiles.

The Israeli military said its recent strike in the Beirut suburbs, which risked reigniting the fierce conflict in Lebanon, had [killed a Hezbollah commander](#).

Politics

A panel of federal judges ruled that Trump's attempt to impose a 10 percent tariff on most U.S. imports, made in response to an earlier Supreme Court setback, [was illegal](#).

Tennessee [approved a new congressional map](#) likely to eliminate the state's lone Democratic House seat by slicing up Memphis.

Secretary of State Marco Rubio and Pope Leo [spoke in private at the Vatican](#). Trump has continued to attack Leo over the pope's stance against the war.

Around the World



Prime Minister Keir Starmer Stefan Rousseau/Press Association, via Associated Press

Britain: Early results in municipal elections show big losses for Prime Minister Keir Starmer's Labour Party. [Follow our updates.](#)

Indonesia: [A volcano eruption](#) killed at least three hikers. Several others are missing.

France: A new law makes it easier [to return looted African art](#) to the country's former colonies.

Cruise Ship Outbreak

Health experts are not particularly worried about a wider outbreak of hantavirus: The infection needs close contact over time to spread. But they are worried that the Trump administration [isn't prepared to manage a future pandemic](#).

A YouTuber from Turkey was on board the MV Hondius, the cruise ship where the virus struck, when the first passenger died. He spoke with The Times about the experience. **Click to play.**



The New York Times

ASK THE MORNING

Why does the United States maintain so many military bases in the Middle East? How do we compare with Russia and China? How many military bases do *they* have in foreign countries? | Tom Ahlberg | Gig Harbor, Washington

Anton Troianovski, who covers global diplomacy, writes:

The Persian Gulf war in 1991 ushered in the era of permanent, large-scale military bases in the Middle East — in part to protect oil supplies. The rationale evolved to include crushing Al Qaeda, promoting democracy and fighting the Islamic State. The bases are part of a military network spanning the globe that officials say helps project America's economic and political power. Russia and China also have global ambitions, but their military footprint is much smaller. Russia's main military presence outside the former Soviet Union is in Syria, where its influence has declined after the fall of the Assad regime in 2024. China has an African base near the Red Sea and is expanding elsewhere — Cambodia, for instance.

Have a question for The Morning? [Ask us here](#).

OPINIONS

Meta is dying, despite its immense wealth and influence, **Julia Angwin** writes, arguing users should log off and [close this chapter of the social-media revolution](#).

The Pentagon says the war in Iran has cost \$25 billion. But the economist **Justin Wolfers** estimates that the true cost will be in the [hundreds of billions of dollars](#), possibly trillions.

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MORNING READS



From a family photo album. Graham Dickie for The New York Times

Remembering: New brain research might someday help people with dementia [preserve their memories](#).

Influenced: Half of U.S. adults under 50 get health and wellness information [from influencers or podcasters](#), research found.

Your pick: The most-clicked story in The Morning yesterday was about [doing the minimal effective amount of exercise](#).

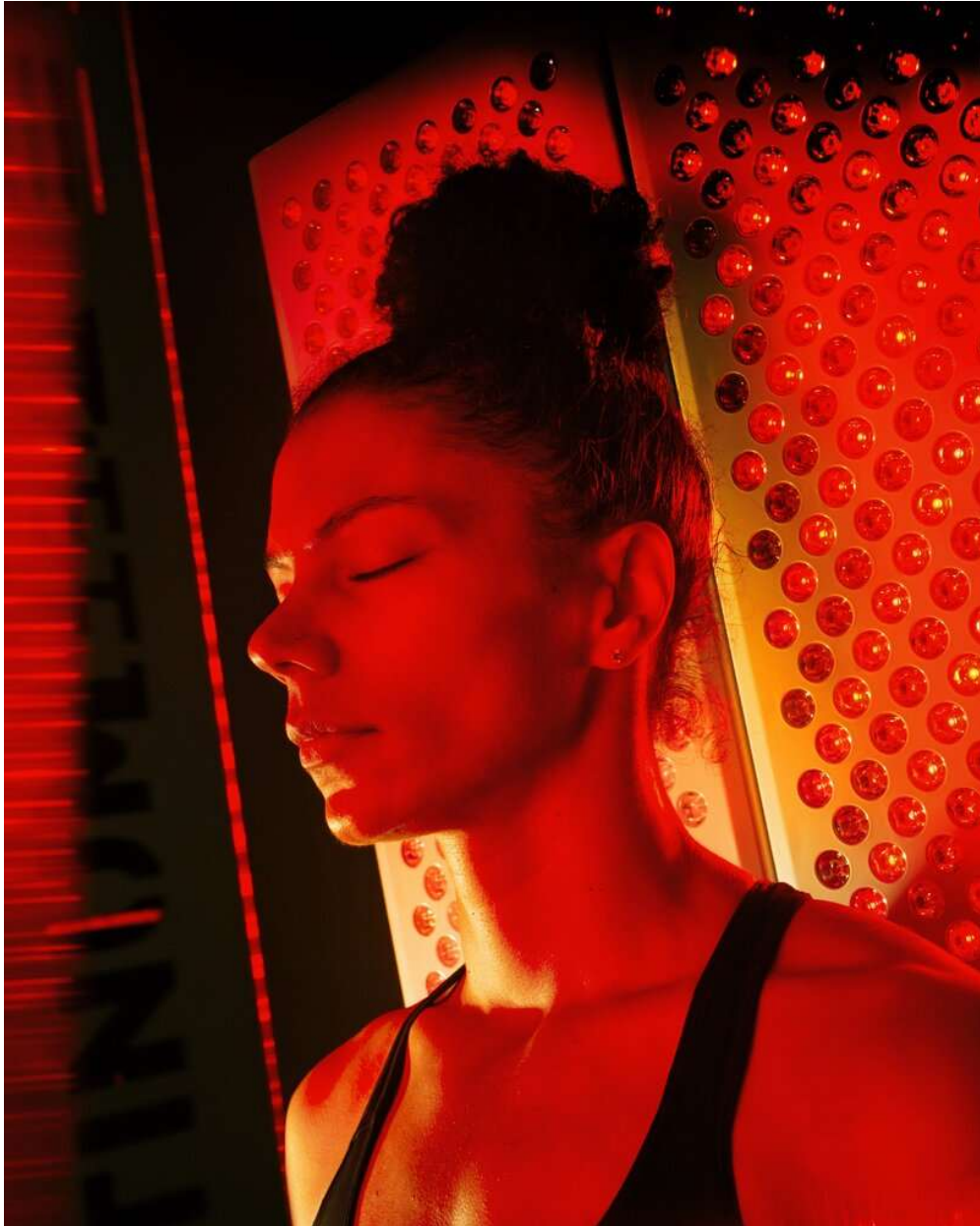
TODAY'S NUMBER

72,000

— That is how many children participated in a recent digital detox across five European countries, giving up their smartphones or strictly limiting their time

online. *The Times* interviewed 14 Austrian participants about the experience. “The children [spoke of a world transformed](#),” wrote our reporter. 

SPORTS



Alysha Clark, 38, the oldest player in the W.N.B.A., uses red-light therapy to recover. Dina Litovsky for The New York Times

Longevity: With cutting-edge sports medicine and sci-fi gadgetry, more athletes are figuring out [how to extend their careers](#).

N.B.A. playoffs: The No. 1 seeds in both conferences took 2-0 series leads over their opponents. The Oklahoma City Thunder defeated the Los Angeles Lakers [125-107](#) in the West semifinals, and the Detroit Pistons beat the Cleveland Cavaliers [107-97](#) in the East.

W.N.B.A.: The Toronto Tempo, a new franchise that [began assembling a roster 35 days ago](#), will play its first game today.

RECIPE OF THE DAY



Christopher Simpson for The New York Times

If you're going to win Mother's Day this year — and I want you to! — I think it's worth it to read down [this recipe for pancakes](#) today and maybe even take a practice run at making them tomorrow, in advance of the M.D. show on Sunday. They're an adaptation of the famous flapjacks from the Golden Diner in Manhattan's Chinatown. They're not difficult to make, but there are a lot of steps. Attend to each one carefully and victory is yours.

AN AMERICAN ABROAD



“Not Yet Titled” by Alma Allen. Casey Kelbaugh for The New York Times

Jason Farago, our art critic, went to Italy to take in the U.S. Pavilion at the Venice Biennale. The Trump administration drafted Alma Allen, “a competent but hardly compelling sculptor of bronze and marble plaques and curlicues,” to promote American values there.

How’d that go? “The 20-odd sculptures here, ranging from a gourd of Mexican onyx to a stylized bronze of a boy clutching his legs, look fine enough for a South Beach hotel lobby,” Jason writes. “They do not offend, except in their inertness.” [Read all about the American’s show at the “Epcot of art.”](#)

More on culture

Nitsuh Abebe, who writes the “On Language” column, is just great on the proliferation in the American marketplace of [“tactical” gear](#): consumer goods designed as if for warriors, then sold to the sort of people warriors

call “mall ninjas,” or “Gravy SEALs.” Tactical pens, coffee-delivery systems, belts? A tactical diaper bag? Sure. Would deploy.

Late night hosts joked [about Rubio’s papal visit](#).

THE MORNING RECOMMENDS

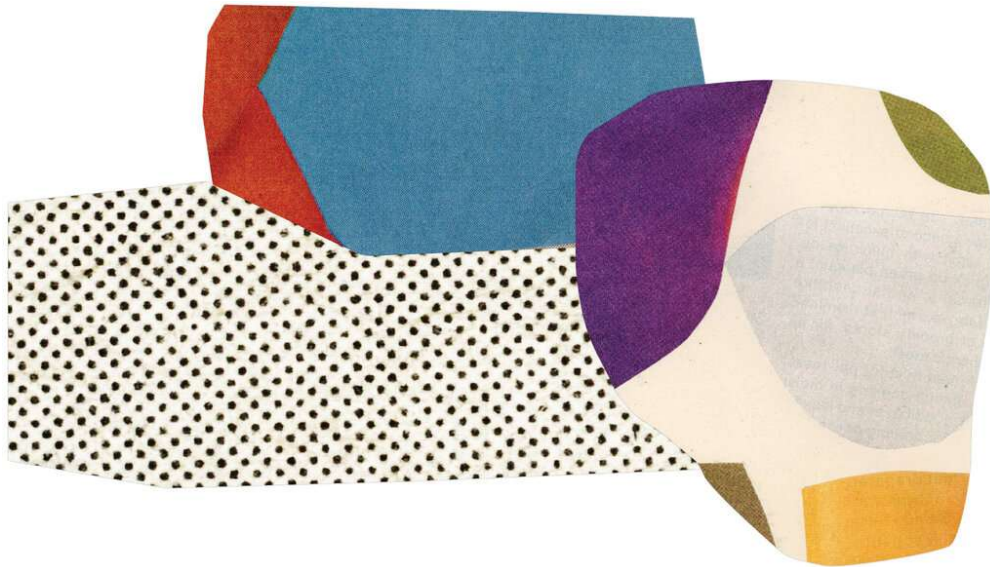


Illustration by John Gall

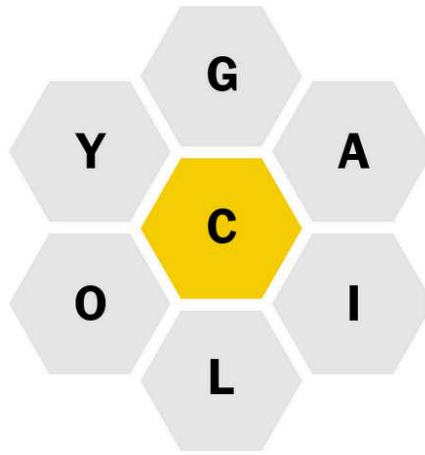
Add some delight to your day. Subscribe to Melissa Kirsch’s newsletter “[The Good List](#).” This week’s edition brought birds, treasure hunting and yet more balloons lost to high ceilings.

Replace [the pulls on your cabinets](#) and realize you don’t need a new kitchen after all.

Listen to Mozart’s Piano Concertos Nos. 9 & 22, with Jan Lisiecki on the keys in front of the Bamberg Symphony Orchestra. It’s one of [five new classical albums you can stream right now](#).

Take [our news quiz](#).

GAMES



Here is [today's Spelling Bee](#). Yesterday's pangram was *immunized*.

And here are [today's Mini Crossword](#), [Wordle](#), [Connections](#), [Crossplay](#) and [Strands](#).

***Thanks for spending part of your morning with The Times and me.
See you tomorrow. — Sam***

Reach our team at themorning@nytimes.com.



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